Letting the Cat Out of the Bag

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/22655392.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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by JaneTheNya

Summary

An AU taking place at the end of Season 2, in which instead of going to Scorpia about Shadow Weaver's escape, Catra leaves the Horde. After surrendering herself to the Rebellion, she's kept as a prisoner, but Adora is set on helping her get better, and shockingly, she isn't the only one.

Chapter 1

Glimmer watched, still in shock, as Catra's body moved slowly up and down with her breathing, laying at the foot of her bed, asleep now. As the sun crept over the horizon, a glare from the window lit her face, the same one that had glared at Glimmer and her comrades countless times in the heat of battle. This wasn't about to stop being weird any time soon.

She still couldn't believe it; it was as jolting to her now as it had been the night before when Catra had appeared in the doorway of her room, her eyes focused on the floor, mumbling softly.

"Don't make fun of me," she had said. "I can't sleep alone right now, okay? I keep seeing *her* face everywhere. In the darkness." She had looked on the verge of tears, and in a state of tiredness, and perhaps a lapse in judgment, Glimmer had let her inside.

She tried to tell herself she was regretting that decision now, but she truly wasn't. She couldn't very well hate Catra right now if she tried, not with the way she looked at the moment.

Glimmer sat herself up in the bed, watching Catra as she slept. She looked over her bruised, scarred legs, focusing on them. Her gaze drifted gradually to her arms, also plenty scarred, but it was clear that not all of those scars were from combat. A pair of elevated, cross-crossed white-pink scars on each wrist told a story that didn't require words. She decided to avert her gaze, moving onto her face, sleeping softly, looking strangely gentle. Catra's face was usually twisted into some form of smirk or grin, but as she slept it was a vulnerable, peaceful expression for once. Her hair, for once without her mask, finally free to fall loosely at the side of her face. Even now, there was exhaustion in her expression. It was evident that she didn't get a lot of sleep

Glimmer shook her head. Why was she feeling so sorry for her? Why was she sympathizing with an enemy- no, a *prisoner of war*? She'd hurt people so many times, she'd hurt Adora most of all…

But… was that why Adora had hugged her so closely when she appeared at Brightmoon's gates? Was that why she cried so happily, sobbing into her, just repeating whisperers of "you're safe now"?

No matter how much Glimmer wanted to hate Catra, it was clear how Adora felt. She was relieved beyond words, happier than ever, for the first time able to know without a doubt that her childhood friend was with her, was safe. That had to be just because they had known each other so long, didn't it?

The kind of abuse Adora had faced at the Horde's hands gave Glimmer chills every time they popped up. How could someone so kind have lived that much of her life under the thumb of such cruel people? It was remarkable that she'd been able to get out and never turn back.

Remarkable… maybe Adora was truly remarkable, and not just for being She-Ra. She was remarkable for her strength of will to escape her abusers and never look back.

Maybe not everybody had that strength.

Her eyes went back to Catra's sleeping face. Exhausted, totally knocked out, on the foot of Glimmer's bed. Just like Adora, she couldn't sleep alone, it seemed. Glimmer allowed a smile to creep onto her face. She really did feel happy that Catra was here now. She had a feeling, too, that it wasn't just because she was happy for Adora's sake. She was happy for Catra, too. She was happy that another victim had escaped their abuse.

A knock came at the door. And again. Catra twitched in her sleep, grimacing. Glimmer let out a groan before teleporting down from her bed to the door and opening it just a crack.

Before her stood her mother, the queen of Brightmoon. A serious expression was on her face as she glared down at Glimmer.

"Glimmer, have you seen the prisoner?" she asked firmly. A moment of panic went through Glimmer's mind. Did she lie, and

help Catra sneak back into the spare room later? It seemed like that plan wouldn't work. That plan also gave Catra the ability to escape, and if there was one thing Glimmer knew about Catra, it was that she was good at making an escape. Why should she lie for her, anyway?

And yet, a part of her conscience tugged at her. She didn't really think Catra wanted to escape. If she had surrendered herself as a part of some scheme, it certainly hadn't clicked with anyone yet what her end goal was. That, and she had to have some serious acting skills.

Groaning in anticipation of what was coming, Glimmer pushed the door the rest of the way open and pointed to her bed, aloft in the room. Catra's tail hung limply from the edge.

"Glimmer!" came the queen's immediate shouting.

Glimmer hushed her. "Keep it down, mom! There's… no reason to wake her up," she could feel the queen's gaze on her as her eyes darted to the floor.

"What are you TALKING about?" the queen demanded. "Glimmer, WHY is our prisoner in your ROOM?"

She kept staring at the floor. She didn't know what she was doing, exactly, or why. She figured she didn't do herself any good trying to lie, in this situation. It was too early in the morning for it, anyway.

"She can't sleep, mom… she's like Adora."
"WHAT? What is going ON here, Glimmer!?"
"She came to my room last night, she was desperate!" She could feel her frustration welling up, but she didn't know why. Sticking up for Catra of all people wasn't exactly something she had ever expected to be doing.
"How did she escape the holding cell?" Angella pressured.
"Do you mean the SPARE ROOM?" Glimmer spat back, annoyed.

Finally, the queen let out a sigh, relaxing her body. She lifted a hand to her forehead and looked at Glimmer.
"Glimmer, listen, I don't know what exactly is going on, but you will bring her down at once, and she will return to the prison for interrogation. She is a danger to all of us, an enemy of our forces, and a high-ranking officer in the Horde. She is one of our greatest enemies and she has no problem with manipulating you or I or Adora or ANYONE to get what she wants. She is not a person who can be trusted and I very much doubt she's the type of person who would just suddenly turn away from the Horde. You would do well to remember that and to avoid letting her get inside your head."

Glimmer sighed. She knew that all made sense, and she knew it was probably true. She couldn't trust someone who had been their enemy for so long just like that. At the same time, though, she couldn't help herself. Something about her sleeping face, the pain in her expression when she appeared last night, keep tugging at her mind.

"Give me a break," came another voice, interrupting her train of thought.

A loud "***thunk***" echoed through the room as Catra landed on the floor nearby. She took a few steps until she was beside Glimmer, her eyes fixated on the floor, not daring to look up at either of the other women. She gripped her left arm firmly in her right hand, but she couldn't hide the shaking in her hands entirely. The claws on her right hand protracted slowly, digging into her other arm.

"If I was gonna try and manipulate somebody, you don't think I would've gone to Adora first?" She grimaced. "Listen, I just went to the first room I could find. I was…" she hesitated to continue, her mouth hanging open but failing to speak. "I was scared, okay?"

She finally allowed her eyes to drift up, looking first at Glimmer, then the queen, the latter of whom's expression remained stern and unyielding. Glimmer fought back her guilt, trying her best to

appear strong as well. After glancing between the two for a moment, the pleading expression in Catra's eyes faded, turning to a frustrated grimace.

Finally, it seemed, Catra gave up waiting for a response. She took another step forward, in front of the queen. "Just take me away, alright? I'm not gonna do anything." She offered her wrists, waiting in vain for someone to restrain them. The queen looked nervous for a moment as she searched in vain for something to use, before regaining her firm composure.

"Yes, let's get going. Don't think I'll let you pull a stunt like that again. You are a prisoner here, don't forget that." She spun on her heel, motioning for Catra to follow, and began to walk out of the room.

As Glimmer watched Catra follow behind her mother, for a moment, she wanted desperately for her to look back. She prayed to see some sinister smile, some hateful gaze, any indication that this was all just another plot to destroy them.

She just wanted her to stop looking so pathetic, so defeated. It was easy to hate Catra when she was fighting back, but now, somehow, it was becoming a lot harder to ignore that memory in her mind of the fear in her eyes, the shaking in her hands, and the criss-cross scars on her wrists.

Chapter 2

"Adora, I think that's a bad idea. And usually I'm the one who comes up with these ideas, so that's saying something!"

Adora stood in the middle of Glimmer's room, shaking slightly, clearly tense. There was determination in her eyes. She looked tired.

Glimmer sat on the cushioned spot by the window, next to Bow. Both of them were watching Adora with concern.

"Glimmer, please, let me get in and see her," Adora pleaded again. She stared directly into Glimmer's eyes. "Please trust me. I'm not a child running from my problems anymore. I was able to withstand Shadow Weaver's tricks on Mysticore, and I can stand up to Catra's too." She paused for a moment before quietly adding on, "if this really is just a trick."

Glimmer hopped up from her seat. "THAT'S what I'm talking about, Adora! You keep believing there's some good in Catra that you can tap into, but it's not safe to try that!" She paused, her eyes looking away once Adora's met them. She held her left wrist in her right arm, biting her lip and nervously looking away. "I just don't want her to hurt you."

Adora sighed, and took another step toward Glimmer, placing a hand on her shoulder. Glimmer looked back, finally making eye contact. Adora gave a soft smile.

"Hey, listen to me, okay? I know you're just looking out for me, and I appreciate that." The smile quickly vanished from her face. "You just have to understand. Catra's been through… a lot. I'm not saying I'm just going to forget about everything that happened, but I know she can change. I mean, I changed, right?" She smiled again, giving a small shrug. She still hadn't stopped shaking.

As Adora finished speaking, Glimmer's eyes drifted down again, to the floor. She couldn't seem to find the words. Luckily, she and Bow often shared the same ideas. The boy hopped up from his seat as well, approaching them and meeting Adora's expression.

"We don't want to fight you on this," he said confidently. "We just want you to be safe. We know how much you care about her, and we just… we don't want you to get hurt if this doesn't go the way you're hoping."

Finally, Adora's shoulders slumped, and she lowered herself to a squatting position on the floor. "I know. I just can't set my feelings aside until I can talk to her."

Bow turned to Glimmer, offering a nod and a reassuring smile. Glimmer returned the smile, nervously, as she approached Adora and offered a hand.

"Okay," she spoke, giving her best impression of confidence. "Let's go. But we're going with you, and we'll be there the whole time." Adora looked up at her, lifting a sleeve to wipe the tears from her eyes, and smiling back.

"Of course!" she said back, confidence in her voice.

With a group teleport, they were around the corner, in the hall leading to the guest room. Two guards stood watch over the door.

"So you're sure no one is in there with her right now?", Adora asked. Glimmer nodded. "Okay then," she continued. "Let's go!"

With another teleport, suddenly they were in a dark room, albeit a room furnished every bit as well as the other bedrooms in the castle. The only light in the room came from a circle of blue magic surrounding a couch in the room's center. Inside the circle laid Catra, curled up and facing away from the group. They stepped forward together, still hand-in-hand.

"Hey Adora," she mumbled from her position, without moving. "I figured you guys would sneak in here eventually."

"Catra… are you okay?" Adora asked, taking another step forward, approaching hesitantly. Catra remained motionless, still looking away, her face buried in her arms.

"Aside from this magic circle Sparkles' mom here put me into, sure, I'm just peachy." Her voice was strained and cracked as she spoke, as though she was fighting back tears, still keeping up a tough exterior.

"I'm sorry they restrained you with… this," Adora said, gesturing to the circle of energy. No response came. "I guess they're considering you a top priority prisoner." She could hear Catra scoff.

"Listen, I really don't know what to do or how to feel, okay? I just wanna know what happened to make you come here and surrender yourself." That seemed to be enough to get her attention. Finally, Catra's head turned to face the group, her dichromatic eyes digging into Adora with her gaze.

"You wanna know what happened? Why, are you ready to hate me, too?" She lifted herself with her arms and pounced across the couch that was encircled by the blue glow, sitting atop its arm and meeting Adora's eyes. It was easy to tell she'd been crying.

"I'm an *idiot*, Adora. I kept on chasing people's approval forever 'cause I wasn't able to recognize I'm never gonna be good enough to get it. I was so desperate to earn her trust that I ruined everything for myself, and now I can never go back."

It was at that moment that Adora noticed Catra's force captain badge was also gone. It seemed she had stripped herself of everything representing her relationship to the Horde.

"Catra, what do you mean…?" Adora asked hesitantly. A burst of blue energy shot up between the two women's faces as Catra's claws made harsh contact with the barrier. Adora stumbled backwards in surprise. Bow and Glimmer instinctively took a fighting position behind her. Adora watched as she lowered her

arm and then stuck the barrier again, this time with her fist. "Catra, doesn't that hurt…?" she began to mumble.

"I'm talking about *her*! Shadow Weaver!" Catra began to cry as she shouted, striking the barrier again with her free hand's claws. "I let her trick me! I let her use me, and manipulate me, and now she's escaped!"

As though saying the words had made it real again, Catra closed her eyes tightly, retracting her arms from the barrier to cover her head as she screamed in fear, stumbling backwards and falling onto the couch.

"Catra, it's okay, she can't hurt you here…!" Adora spoke quickly, taking a step forward and reaching out a hand, only to be intercepted by a shock from the barrier. Her eyes darted around uncomfortably, looking for something that couldn't exist, some way inside the barrier, some way to reach her.

Catra jolted uncomfortably, cradling herself in her arms. Eventually, she settled down, rising from her position and looking helplessly at Adora before grimacing again.

"I'm *hopeless*, okay? Hordak is gonna kill me if I go back. He never appreciated any of my work, anyway. I did everything for him- and for Shadow Weaver- and I never got anything in return but hurt. Just 'cause I was never special, like you are."

She crawled back onto the couch, laying down facing away from the group once again. "I have no more *use* to give anyone. So I figured I'd stay here with you and your merry little gang, because you guys are dumb enough to keep me alive."

As she finished speaking and her head returned to its position, protected by her arms, the room fell silent. Adora, Glimmer, nor Bow had any idea what to say next.

Finally, Glimmer stepped forward, placing a hand gently on Adora's shoulder. Only then did Adora herself recognize the shaking in her body, the discomfort. Was this from the realization

that Shadow Weaver was once again on the loose? Was it a fear of what was happening in Catra's internal dialogue?

Whatever it was, she didn't get a chance to figure it out. The door to the room slowly opened as Angella took a step inside.

"Adora, Glimmer, Bow!" she shouted out in anger as she noticed them. "Get out of here this minute! I am here to interrogate the prisoner and I will not have you interfering and sneaking about this time!"

As Glimmer searched her mind for an excuse, the queen took another step toward them in the center of the room.

Before any of the others could react, Adora had drawn her sword, pointing it in the queen's direction. The sudden and aggressive motion was so startling that it even caught Catra's attention.

"No, you're not gonna touch her," Adora spoke firmly, her hand still shaking as it gripped the handle of the sword. "You won't take another step forward, I won't let you."

Glimmer dashed forward, placing herself between Adroa and the queen. "Adora, what are you doing!?" As she moved in front of her, Glimmer could finally notice the tears streaming down Adora's face.

Adora's arm, still gripping the sword, fell limply to her side, the top of the blade clanking against the hard tile floor. "I can't let her talk to Catra alone. I don't know what'll happen. Look at her, she's scared, she's… she's so broken, I don't know if she can take it."

At last, the queen dropped her stern gaze, lifting a hand gently to reach out. "Adora…" she began softly.

Adora's free hand tightened into a fist as she gritted her teeth before speaking. "THIS is what the Horde DOES. This is what Shadow Weaver does! This is what they always do, all of them!"

She turned around to look at Catra again, whose eyes immediately looked away. Adora's expression softened. "I just hope it's not too late to save her," she whispered. She shut her eyes tightly, and began to run out of the room, her friends following after her and calling her name.

The queen sighed as she watched them go, with the doors closing behind her, taking another look at her prisoner.

Chapter 3

Catra stayed in place, curled up in a corner of the small couch to which she was restricted. She wasn't trying to sleep, she knew she wouldn't be able to. Even in her conscious state, the darkness wasn't making it any easier not to see Shadow Weaver's form lurking in every corner of the room.

She sniffled again, rubbing at her eyes with her arm. Seeing Adora like that had brought back more emotions than she was prepared to handle. It was one thing to see her in the midst of a battle, already transformed into She-Ra. It was quite another to sit there helplessly and watch as she drew her sword on a queen to protect, of all people, her.

She opened her eyes again to a grim, frustrated stare. What were all these feelings? Sadness, longing, guilt… frustration, anger. She extended her claws and swiped again at the barrier. Another shock of blue light, a jolt of energy through her skin. She let out a hiss in protest.

Suddenly, another source of light appeared in the dark room. A bright, purple aura surrounding Princess Glimmer as she appeared in the room, alone. The light was pleasant, but it faded quickly.

"Ugh. Hey, Glimmer, why are *you* here? I was expecting Adora, if anybody," Catra groaned tiredly.

"You got my name right," Glimmer commented.
"I'm too tired to mess it up on purpose."
"You were doing that on *purpose!?*"
"Anyway, why are you here?"

The princess let out a long sigh, looking at Catra with an infuriating pity in her eyes. It was a look she didn't see from her often. Usually they only met in the heat of a fight, Glimmer enraged that Catra remained standing in their way. The softness was usually reserved for Adora. Like everything.

Catra put on her best scowl before looking away, hissing again. It was pretty hard to seem threatening when you'd obviously just been crying your eyes out, but that wasn't going to stop her from trying. "Here to laugh at me, and mock me, because I'm your prisoner now? Go ahead, if you want, I don't care anymore."

Glimmer let out another sigh. When Catra looked back, her expression was still gentle. That was infuriating. Why couldn't she just get angry and leave her alone already?

"I wanted to ask why you came to my room the other night," the princess explained. "That was insanely out of character for you."

Catra scoffed, her tail swishing in front of her body to create some barrier, however small, between the two. "Don't think into it too much, I wasn't feeling much like myself that day anyway. I came here and surrendered, after all."

Glimmer shook her head, unconvinced. "No, there's definitely more to it than that. You've been acting differently ever since you got here. It's subtle, but you're not acting like a jerk as easy as you usually do. It feels like you actually have to *try* to find ways to get us annoyed with you."

That was interesting enough to get Catra to look at her, at least. She did all she could to stare a hole into her, her frustration reinvigorated. "Well I'm not your *enemy* anymore, am I, Sparkles? I'm just a prisoner of war now, so why should I waste my energy on working you up anymore? You're the idiots who have decided to care so much about how I feel."

That got her expression to shift, but only for a moment. The twitch of familiar anger in Glimmer's face immediately dying down with a sigh as she regained her composure. Her expression wasn't angry, it was sad, horribly, painfully sad. And that infuriated Catra more than anything else.

"So what are you here for, princess, you think you're gonna turn me around? Think you're gonna get me to apologize and

everything is gonna be better? Are you forgetting about everything I did, all the ways I hurt Adora? Here, want me to remind you?" She extended her claws, putting on her most hateful glare as she thrusted her arm against the barrier again, illuminating her face with the jolt of blue energy. It was really starting to sting.

"Catra, stop." The princess' expression was serious now, but she hadn't changed her position. It was the first time Catra had seen her like this, this serious and composed. "That isn't gonna work, you're not gonna scare us into abandoning you to whatever you think is gonna happen. I don't think you want that either, since you came here for a reason."

That was enough to get a laugh out of Catra. She lifted a hand to her face and let out a long, hysterical laugh, eventually speaking through it. "You think I came here so you could *save* me? Oh, princess, you really are dumb!"

This would be enough. As her laughter settled down she hopped onto the arm of the couch, on Glimmer's level, meeting her expression with a sinister grin. "I came here to *use* you guys. I'm just taking advantage of you. I know you soft hero types are too stupid to execute a prisoner, even one as dangerous as me, so I'm just gonna kick back here and stay safe from the Horde. That way, even in the end, I still *win*."

For a moment, Catra was satisfied with herself. That would have almost certainly been enough, usually. But somehow, it wasn't. Glimmer's expression hadn't changed, it was still serious, she hadn't been worked up yet. When she finally spoke, it was short, but it was exactly the words needed to completely shatter Catra's persona.

"I know you're scared, Catra. It'll be okay." With that, another flash of purple light emerged, and she was gone.

A scream originating from the spare room echoed down the halls of the castle. Sparks of blue light flied as Catra's claws, fists and

legs continued to make contact with the barrier again and again.

Chapter 4

There was a tension in the air as Adora, Glimmer, and Bow walked into the room and took their seats around the large silver table. None of them made eye contact with anyone. The queen, sitting at the head of the table, remaining silent, as did the other princesses, Nettossa, and Spinnerella.

Eventually, the queen's voice broke the silence. "This meeting of the Princess Alliance will now convene." As she finished, Adora rose to her feet. Next to her, Glimmer and Bow looked up in shock. The queen fought back a sigh as she spoke. "You have something to ask, Adora?"

Adora took a deep breath, her eyes closed, before looking at the queen with a determined gaze. "I know releasing the prisoner is off the table," she began. "But I would like to propose the magic field she is being kept in be dispelled."

"Denied," came the queen's immediate response. "She is a high priority prisoner and she has proven that she will utilize free reign of the castle if she is given the opportunity." She shot a glare at Glimmer, who kept her head down.

Adora gripped her arm uncomfortably in her hand and bit her lip. The others- Perfuma, Mermista, and Frosta- were watching her with concern in their expressions. She shut her eyes tightly as she tried to focus, tried to pick her words, but it was to no avail. She opened her eyes weakly, looking down, refusing to meet anyone's gaze.

"Your majesty, she's… she's *hurting* herself with that barrier. You at least-" she paused as hesitation struck her to finish that thought. "You at least don't want to let her kill herself before she can provide you with any information, right?" Adora's distressed eyes finally glanced up to meet the queen's.

Angella sighed, her own serious expression dropping as she hesitated to speak. Finally, she regained her composure, speaking decisively. "I understand how you're feeling, Adora. This can't be easy for you. And I'm sorry. But you must understand. I cannot act on your emotions alone. The prisoner has not given us information. She is avoiding speaking to me at all costs. It seems very probable she is attempting to take advantage of our good will. And we must not be weak if this moment calls for strength."

"She's SCARED!" came Adora's response, a loud cry as she slammed a fist on the table. "I keep telling you, this isn't just her fault! THIS is what the Horde does to people!"

She looked around at them now, the eyes of the other princesses and her friends on her as she spoke. She was filled with too much distress to care. "She's spent her *whole life* like this. This is what the Horde has taught her, and I… I didn't help, either! I was always the special one, but I didn't think about what that meant for her! I didn't think about what would happen when I left. I still don't know what she went through after that. I… as soon as I got out, once I met you guys, once I was safe, I gave up on her, I didn't even try to bring her back like I should have, and instead I made sure the only path she had left to go down was leading into further darkness, I… I made her this way. I'm at least partly to blame."

She felt a hand from her friends on each shoulder, Glimmer and Bow each on either side, the latter speaking first. "Adora, this isn't your fault," he said firmly, flashing her a patient smile. "You can't blame yourself for everything that happened. You had to take care of yourself first."

Glimmer nodded, speaking up as well. "You guys went through the same thing in there. It isn't your fault that she couldn't change. You had to take the time to escape for yourself, you had your own problems you had to solve first. I mean… you still do."

Adora gave a weak smile, finally allowing herself to make eye contact with the others. "Thanks, you guys, but that isn't all

necessarily true. We *didn't* go through the same things. It took me too long to realize that, and it might be too late."

There was a silence in the room. No one wanted to speak, nobody knew what they would say. Even Queen Angella had fallen uncharacteristically silent. Adora began shaking her head, slowly, and speeding up with a panic.

"You majesty, I'm sorry. I have to see her. Let me into the room. You know I'll just sneak in anyway. This way, you can come with me." Her movements settled, staring at the queen with a determined glare, awaiting a response.

"Very well, Adora, but this is the last time. If nothing comes of this conversation, I am commanding you to drop the subject." She paused. "I feel it is only fair to inform you that I have also considered a trade of our prisoner for the safe return of Princess Entrapta."

Adora's eyes shot up. "You can't! I mean, you can't send her back there! We can't do that to her. Please."

The queen lifted a hand. "There is no guarantee that they would take such a deal, if the Horde is to communicate with us to begin with. I am only saying that a former ally who can likely be turned and whose intelligence has greatly helped the Horde is a far more valuable asset to us than a prisoner who refuses to speak. I am acting strategically, nothing more."

Adora turned her head away sharply, betrayal in her tone. "Let's go, then. Please." The queen gave a reluctant nod as she stood from her seat.

"We're coming too!" insisted Glimmer as she followed after Adora, Bow behind her. "Even if you try to stop us, we're gonna get in there anyway, and you know it."

The queen sighed and gave a silent nod, indicating for the pair to follow. As they made their way out the door and into the castle's hallway, she turned to face the remaining guests, a tired

embarrassment in her expression. “I apologize for this. We will all be right back, and our meeting will continue as normal.”

The door closed shut, only to open again a moment later. The three remaining princesses quickly jumped backward towards their seats.

“And I’d ask that you, at least, stay here.”

Chapter 5

The doors to the guest room creaked open once again, as Catra raised her head from her position on the couch. It wasn't as though she was getting any sleep anyway, but the back-and-forth of this all was getting frustrating. She groaned and hopped to a squatted position balanced atop the back of the couch to greet the entering party. Holding herself up in position quickly became painful, her arms still burning from her tantrum the previous night. She grimaced as she fought the pain.

"Hey Adora," she hummed mockingly, trying to hold back all those emotions and all the physical pain she was currently in. It wasn't easy to keep her composure when she saw the desperate plea in her eyes. She let out a growl and turned her head away.

"Catra, please, will you talk to me? I'm begging you, please… I want you to be safe. I want you to stay here with me, with us. I want to help you get better. I want to live with you again, I want you in my life again, I want to see you smile, a real genuine smile again." Adora was crying now, and for as much as she tried to hide it, so was Catra.

She wouldn't let that last for long. She mustered the deep-seated grudge and jealousy in her heart and wiped her eyes with her singed arm, still in pain from all the repeated shocks. Adora began to pipe up to ask about it, but Catra was quick to cut her off.

"So you brought the whole squad, huh? And the queen, too? Wow, Adora, you have so many friends. So much support. Everybody loves you here. Just like in the Horde. You're so special, even our *abusers* loved you! But they didn't love you enough, did they?" She gritted her teeth as she dug her claws into the fabric of the couch. "And *I* didn't love you enough, either. So you went and found somewhere even nicer, where they love you even more!" She shot a look at Glimmer and Bow.

"I thought that meant it was my turn to be loved. But it wasn't. Shadow Weaver didn't love me after you left, she just *blamed* me that you were gone. And for a moment I thought Hordak would recognize me, but boy, was I wrong about that one! Nobody ever loves me because I'm not worth loving." She hissed, looking down, her ears drooping as she spoke softly. "And I mean, I get it." She fought back tears and lost, feeling them stream down her face. She couldn't lie anymore, she couldn't keep it up. "I don't love me either."

The room fell silent. Finally, Adora lifted the sword in the air. "Adora, don't-!" came the queen's futile cry. By the time she could speak, Adora had already finished shouting out, and before long, she had transformed.

Catra looked upon She-Ra's form. It was magnificent, and beautiful. But it wasn't Adora, she had convinced herself, it was just another princess, another enemy. But seeing the look in She-Ra's eyes now, she could no longer pretend than she and Adora were not one and the same. That compassion, determination, and desire to save her were the same as Adora's.

She-Ra lifted the sword to the barrier, tapping it gently against the edge, and closing her eyes. A jolt of blue energy traveled across the sword, dissipating as it reached She-Ra's body. For a moment, she shone with a bright, brilliant golden light, and soon too did the barrier. The bright golden shine overtook the grim, ghostly blue of the magic perimeter and soon both dissolved as one last fantastic shine overtook the room and left Adora standing where She-Ra had just been, dropping her sword to the ground.

At last, she closed the gap, taking a step inside. Nervously, Adora lifted a hand to Catra's arm, tapping it for a moment with her fingers. It burned. She flinched and moved her hand away, reaching up to her face.

Catra's expression was softer now than Adora had ever seen it. She had finally dropped her guard, too tired, too vulnerable now to keep it up any longer. Her face was exhausted, her hair a mess,

and a loose strand hung in front of her face, which Adora carefully swept aside.

"You're *wrong* that you're not worth loving," Adora finally spoke, confidently, moving in closer as she moved her hand to brush along Catra's face. Catra flinched, frowning and looking away. Adora retreated, which caused Catra to turn back. She didn't want that layer of distance anymore, she decided. And it hurt too much to pretend that she did.

"And you're wrong that no one loves you, too," Adora continued, moving in closer again, placing her free hand on the back of Catra's waist, just above her tail, pulling her in a bit closer, but loosely enough that Catra could worm her way out of it if she wanted. "Because *I* love you."

At last, Adora pulled her in, closing the gap entirely as their lips met. Surprised for a moment, Catra flinched, but was quick to adjust herself and lean in, her tail now wrapped itself around Adora's waist. They stayed that way for a long time, breaking apart only when Catra finally needed to speak. She was blushing as she looked away from Adora, guilt in her eyes. "I'm sorry," she mumbled. "For everything, I'm sorry. I'm sorry, I'm sorry…"

She shook her head, panic taking over, beginning to fall backward from her position. Adora's hand, still on Catra's waist, catching her, pulling her closer, moving to wrap around her body completely in a hug. Catra tried weakly to return it, sobbing openly now, finally letting down her guard, dropping her harsh persona, and letting go.

Adora held her tightly in the hug, crying as well, gripping Catra as though she never intended to let go, her eyes tightly shut. "It's okay," she reassured with a soft whisper. "It's all okay. It's like I said. You're safe now. Finally, you're safe."

She loosened her grip, pulling away to take another look at Catra's face, tears welling up again as she realized this was truly real. Her childhood friend, no, her childhood love, was finally in front of her

again. For the first time in a long while, she felt that things were going to be okay, at last.

Chapter 6

Catra awoke in a panic, screaming, claws extended. She shot up from her position, jumping onto the middle of the floor. The room was still enveloped in darkness, it was too dark. She could be anywhere in this darkness. Catra knew that all too well- she had snuck up on her with far less before. Her eyes circled the room, waiting for a voice to break the silence. Her claws ripped open the bandages that had been loosely applied to each arm. It would be a show of weakness to keep them on, and she couldn't risk that. She couldn't show weakness. She would be strong when she spoke, when she finally showed herself. What could Shadow Weaver say, now that Catra had fallen as low as her, losing everything from her illustrious position at Hordak's side?

With a click, the lights came on, illuminating the room. "Catra…?" came a voice from behind her. Catra's eyes darted immediately to the doorway. It was Adora, looking tired, a knife in her hands, just in case, Catra assumed. When Adora saw her eyes fixated on it, she quickly put it away, sliding it into the waistband of her pants.

"Adora, she's here somewhere. You have to know it too," she pleaded through her strained voice, approaching the door nervously. Adora knelt down to reach Catra's level, running a hand softly though her hair. Tears were welling up in Catra's eyes now. "Please. She's here, I can feel it, I can see her in the darkness."

As Catra continued shaking, Adora pulled her into a hug, whispering softly into her ear. "It's okay, she isn't here. No one is here but me, and you're safe now." She repeated the phrase again and again, an action that once would have frustrated Catra. She would have pushed Adora away, angrily hissing that she didn't believe her, and to get away. Now, though, all she could feel was the warmth of Adora's hug, and it was too good to reject. She had been waiting for this feeling for too long, and she was too tired. She hadn't slept nearly enough, she knew, and that was catching up with her now as her eyes slowly shut with the comfort of

knowing she was protected by her once-enemy who would do anything for her.

Catra was still feeling herself drifting off as Adora hoisted her up, carrying her back to the bed. With the magic barrier gone, a bed had now been brought into the room for Catra, though it wasn't making much of a difference to her. It was just another thing to scratch up in the panic of the night.

Fading in and out of consciousness, when she next opened her eyes, she saw Adora again, re-applying fresh bandages to her arms. "Hey Catra," she said in a gentle whisper, without a hint of the irony that phrase now carried. "Please try and keep these on. I know they're uncomfortable, but…" she trailed off, reaching Catra's wrists with the soft gauze wrapping around her arm. She took a silent look at the scars there again, scars she'd seen before, Catra knew. It was uncomfortable enough to make her pipe up, but just as she started, Adora finished applying the bandages.

She flashed a gentle smile back at Catra, still so exhausted she could barely process what was happening, that the person who had betrayed her and left her behind and caused her grief was just… here, now, and that everything was okay. Everything was in the past. She could feel herself crying again, too tired to fight it. It didn't make sense to be so quickly forgiven, to let it all be accepted, and to do the same. Somehow, though, she wouldn't want anything else. In this moment, she had everything she ever wanted.

"I'll stay here with you tonight, okay?" Adora assured, placing a firm hand on Catra's leg. "I could use the company, too. I still can't sleep very well on my own, either." Catra's hand loosely reached up around Adora's waist. The knife was gone. That was probably a good thing. She moved her arm around the back of her waist instead, pulling Adora in closer, hugging her. A shout of surprise evolved into happy giggles as the two lay together on the bed. A hand reached the back of Catra's head, pulling her in closer until the two's foreheads were touching.

“I love you, Adora.” She didn’t know where those words came from, but they felt good to say. Unbelievably good. Catra had been, in some sense, waiting a lifetime for the opportunity to say them. And she had awaited with equal urgency what she heard in response.

“I love you too, Catra.” With those words, Catra closed her eyes again. She was safe now, she knew. She drifted- peacefully for the first time- into sleep.

Chapter 7

The door to Glimmer's room opened with a slow creak as Adora made her way inside, a shy look on her face. She knew this conversation was going to have to happen, but that hadn't made it any less awkward.

Finally, Adora lifted her head to look around. Glimmer and Bow were kneeling around a small table, and upon noticing her, Glimmer had hopped to her feet with a smile.

"Oh, Adora!" she announced cheerily. "There you are!" Adora sheepishly rubbed the back of her neck with her hand, still avoiding eye contact. A hug from Glimmer quickly put an end to that, however.

"Gosh, Glimmer, I…" she trailed off, giving a bit of a smile. "I was a little nervous to talk to you, after what happened and everything."
"What do you mean?" she responded, pulling away from Adora enough to give a confused look.
"Well, I mean, I kissed Catra, and then I spent the night with her. I thought it was pretty obvious we were gonna be dating now, and I thought you might not like that. I know you're okay with me dating other people, but I know you don't really get along with Catra, and so I wasn't sure if you would-" she was cut off promptly as Glimmer planted a quick kiss on her lips, smiling up at her as they broke away.

Glimmer backed up, offering a hand, which Adora happily took, and led her to the table. Bow sat in his spot, unmoved and still intimately focused on something. Adora poked her head around do try and take a look before turning back to Glimmer. "What's Bow doing?" she asked.

With that, his head shot up, seemingly returning to focus. "Oh! I'm making Catra a mini-figure, duh. If she's gonna be a part of the Best Friend Squad now, she needs one, right?"

He presented a small carved approximation of Catra, the same size as the miniature figures he had previously made of himself, Glimmer, and She-Ra. Adora gave a gentle smile at the gesture. The figure of Catra looked appropriately gloomy. He really did have a talent for craftsmanship. "I love it, I'm sure she will too," Adora replied cheerfully, before thinking to add, "although, she might not act like it at first."

"Anyway, Adora," Glimmer started, causing Adora to snap her attention back to her. "It's not you and Catra dating I have a problem with." She bit her lower lip, looking nervously around the room. Adora waited for her to be ready to give a follow up, though she couldn't help but panic internally about what would be said next.

"Ugh… promise you won't tell anyone about this," Glimmer finally said with a groan. "I can't BELIEVE I'm about to say this, but…" she paused for a moment, sinking lower in her spot kneeling around the table. "I think I… also… like Catra."

Adora shot up, her face lit up with surprise. "Oh! Well that's good then, I was so sure it was gonna be bad! I'm glad to hear that you don't have any bad blood, maybe you two can get along better now!"

There was a long silence in the room, until eventually she heard the noise of Bow's figure being set on the table as he spoke up. "Uh, Adora, I think she means, like… the OTHER kind of like." Immediately, another groan came from Glimmer.

"Wait, huh? HUH!?" Adora quickly looked back and forth between her two friends as the pieces clicked into place in her mind. "Wait, seriously!? Is THAT what you mean!?"

Glimmer hopped from her seat, covering Adora's mouth with her hand. "Yeah, yeah, just don't make a big deal out of it, okay!? Ugh, I can't BELIEVE I fell for that jerk…"

She sunk back to her spot by the table, folding her arms and trying to hide the fact that she was blushing wildly. Adora couldn't help but give a small giggle. "Well, how am I supposed to keep it a secret? Don't you wanna tell her?"
"No way! She'll never let me hear the end of it!" Glimmer replied with a groan.
"I think you're missing the point." Adora laughed.

Eventually, the three of them couldn't help but devolve into group laughter. Once they settled down, Adora cleared her throat, and hesitantly spoke up again.

"There was… one other thing I had to ask about, though," she said in a serious tone. Glimmer and Bow both looked at her and nodded, signalling for her to continue.

"Your mother, Queen Angella, she… is she still gonna keep Catra as a prisoner? Is it possible to convince her to set her free?" There was a long silence, and eventually, Glimmer reached a hand across the table, which Adora took.

"I'm gonna talk to her. I can't promise anything, but trust me to handle this, please. I don't want her to have to stay in there either."
Adora's expression softened as she flashed a grin. "Well of course not," she said smugly. "How are you two gonna get together if she's locked away?"
"Ugh! Shut UP, Adora!" Glimmer responded with a joking frustration. The three all began to laugh again.

Chapter 8

Glimmer ran her hands along Catra's messy hair slowly. She was definitely going to need a bath later, because she didn't smell great. Though Glimmer could hardly blame her, after going through what she did to get to Brightmoon.

She had taken Adora up on an offer, "go visit Catra in the spare room for awhile so she could take a nap safely." That plan also gave Glimmer the albeit awkward opportunity to see Catra again. She watched her body moving slowly up and down, laying her head on Glimmer's lap. She really didn't have as much concern for personal space as she'd let on, at least when it came to doing things she thought would bother Glimmer, like this. Still, Glimmer wasn't necessarily complaining.

She looked down to her arms again, as she had before. She'd kept the bandages on now, which was a relief to practically everyone. With any luck, the burns would start healing up before too long, after being carefully treated.

She ran a hand through her hair again, starting on her forehead. She looked different without that mask on. Her hair was a little more unruly, maybe, but she also looked somehow softer. Missing her belt and her force captain badge, she was now devoid of any symbols tying her to the Horde. It gave a sense of hope that maybe, with any luck, she'd be able to break free from her painful past, soon. Glimmer wanted to help her get there, as she had with Adora. The people hurt by the Horde's manipulation didn't deserve to keep suffering, none of them did. She was glad Catra had finally taken the plunge to get away from them. It wasn't something that came easily, even for Adora, who had the benefit of knowing she was She-Ra, a hero figure who nobody could just turn away and abandon.

She had the feeling things were very different for Catra. No one ever saw her as essential, the most useful she ever was to the Horde was for tracking down Adora. That had made Glimmer

rightfully frustrated in the past, she thought, but now that she was here, sad and tired and broken down, Glimmer saw those things in a different light. She ran her hand through Catra's hair again, whispering softly, "we're not going to abandon you. Promise."

A sudden and loud creak came from behind them on the sofa as the doors swung open. Still asleep, Catra's tail began to twitch violently before settling. Glimmer carefully lifted her head and moved her aside, getting up and turning around to see her mother standing before her.

"Glimmer!" came the queen's shouting, just as Glimmer had anticipated. She let out a defiant groan as she looked back to her mother expectantly.

"What on EARTH are you doing in here with the prisoner!?" she began, clear frustration mixed with tiredness in her voice.

Glimmer gave another sigh, shooting a glare at her mother. "It's like I said before, we're just trying to-!"

She was unable to finish her sentence before the queen's glare silenced her. "Glimmer," she began sternly. "Do you have any idea how uncooperative that prisoner has been? She has given us no information whatsoever."

"She's scared…" Glimmer protested softly, unable to match the annoyance in her mother's tone.

"She is a *Horde soldier*," Angella spoke determinedly. "And not just anyone, the one who led the attack on Brightmoon, lest you forget! The one who has been the biggest threat to the safety of the new She-Ra, our last hope! She is an enemy, and she cannot be trusted! Why don't you understand that, Glimmer!?" There was a pause as Glimmer looked away, biting her lip and gripping her arm. The queen sighed again. "She is a bad person, Glimmer. She cannot be trusted to simply change and renounce her ways."

With those words, something snapped in Glimmer's mind as she looked up, shouting now. "She's not a bad person!" she blurted angrily, surprising even herself with her words. She spoke again, still upset. "Some people may be able to turn around quickly, but for some people it's harder, and it takes time! It doesn't just mean they're bad!" She paused, her tone softening as she continued. "Not everybody is like Adora."

The queen's expression, for the first time, looked genuinely shocked, before returning to a serious position. "Say that's true," she began. "Would a good first step for her not be cooperating and giving us information?"

Glimmer looked at her feet, nervous. "Mom… Adora told me about what happened to her and Catra, as kids. They were raised by Shadow Weaver. That lady who kidnapped and tortured me. And if what Adora says is true, she did the same to Catra. As a child. So doesn't it… I don't know, doesn't it make sense that she'd be scared to disclose everything she knows? She's still terrified of the Horde, especially of Shadow Weaver." She looked up, finally, invigorated with a sense of boldness, meeting her mother's eyes in her gaze. "The least we can do is let her know we've got her back if she helps us, right?"

The queen closed her eyes, giving another exhausted sigh. She smiled faintly as she spoke. "As always, Commander Glimmer, you make a compelling point." With just those words, she turned and began to walk away, stopping. "Your points will be considered," she noted passingly, before walking out the large double-doors and signalling the guards to shut them behind her.

Glimmer breathed a long sigh of relief, turning back to the couch. She couldn't believe she had just said all that, even less so to stick up for Catra of all people. Still, she felt her words rang true. She approached Catra's sleeping form on the couch, poking her head with one finger.

"Hey," she said casually. "You don't have to pretend to be asleep. I know you couldn't have slept through that shouting."

Catra opened her eyes and raised to a sitting position, letting out a short "mrrp" noise that Glimmer hated to admit she thought was cute. She gave a weak smile, more genuine than any of the arrogant grins she'd flashed at Glimmer in the past.

"Can't believe you feel so strongly about protecting me, Sparkles," she said, clearly trying to put on her usual front but still a little too drained to make it convincing. That became even more obvious when she followed it up with a near-silent whisper of "thank you."

Glimmer ran a hand along Catra's hair, petting her as she spoke assuringly, which still felt strange given who she was speaking too. "Listen, I know it's scary, but just try and talk to my mom, okay? Even if you don't want to share certain information, just be honest with her." She was quiet for awhile before moving her hand down, holding the side of Catra's face and looking her in the eyes. "We'll protect you. Promise."

She had half a mind just to kiss Catra there before she noticed the sound of soft purring, and couldn't help but grin. A blush emerged across Catra's face as she pushed Glimmer away. "Okay, okay!" She pouted, leaning away on the couch as her tail swung and wrapped around herself. "You can go now, I've napped enough."

Glimmer gave another smile as she stood, one last plan entering her mind. She began to walk for the door before suddenly teleporting to Catra's side again, planting a kiss on her cheek, and teleporting away. She could hear the embarrassed shout of surprise from the hall outside the room. Mission success.

Chapter 9

"So you will vouch for the prisoner, Adora?" Angella's voice was strained, no doubt still exhausted from recent events.

Adora gave a determined nod, her face still serious. "Yes, your majesty. I believe she will be a crucial asset to the rebellion. She may even help us turn the tide of the war. I truly believe that."

The queen was silent for a moment, thinking. "And her previous actions against the rebellion do not give you pause...?"

Adora took a deep breath before speaking again. "It's not that. I just believe she can change, and I think she's trying." She looked down for a moment, finally breaking with her professional demeanor. "I'm not stupid. I know she's turned me away when I tried to help before. But I also know how hard it is to leave the Horde. Especially for others."

She could feel the eyes of the others on her, expecting her to elaborate. "It was easy for me to leave the Horde," she began. "I'd always been taught I was special, that my sense of justice was right. So I knew I was right, that I was making the right decision." She gave a small laugh. "Even though I doubt they were expecting me to use my sense of justice for this."

Finally, she lifted her face and made eye contact with the queen. "It's hard for her. She has no one else to give her value. But we can give her the purpose and the approval she's always been chasing, I know we can."

There was silence around the table as Adora sat. The queen gave a long pause before standing to her feet. "In light of the arguments from Princess Glimmer and Adora…" she began. There was a cough, and Angella paused and sighed before adding, "...and a very touching note from Bow…" Adora looked to her right at Bow, who looked proud. "We have decided to permit the release of the prisoner with probation."

Neither Adora nor Glimmer could hide their excitement as they looked at each other with bright, energetic smiles emerging across their faces. That was step one, Adora figured, the most important battle was won, but there was still a long uphill climb before things were done.

The rest of the meeting felt like an eternity dragging on as Adora awaited the moment they would finally convene and she would be able to go and see Catra and tell her she was free now, finally. When, at last, Angella announced the end of the meeting, Adora was the first to jump from her seat and make a beeline for the spare room.

She threw open the large double doors excitedly, shouting "Catraaa!" As she looked around the room, she saw the girl hop atop the back of the couch, looking at her.

"Hey Adora," she sounded better now, but still tired. "Why the yelling?" Before she could continue, Adora was already running towards her, tackling her in a hug. "Hey, quit it!" she shouted in protest as the two tumbled backward onto the couch.

"You're free, Catra!" Adora exclaimed with delight. "You can leave the room now! You're officially one of us!"

Catra paused for a moment, shock in her eyes. "Seriously?" Adora leaned back to meet her expression, giving a gentle smile and a nod before enveloping her in another hug. Once again, Catra didn't fight back. Even more, this time, she went so far as to return it, burying her face in Adora's shoulder, staying in place for some time.

Adora put a hand on the back of Catra's head, gently running it along her hair. "Thank you for telling the queen about Hordak and Shadow Weaver," she whispered, still close, reassuring her. "I know it was hard."

She felt Catra's grip around her body tighten instinctively. "It's okay," Adora whispered again, repeating it again as she brushed

along Catra's hair. "You're safe now."

A few moments later, they were joined in the room by the others, Adora helping Catra to her feet to turn and meet them all, flashing a weak smile and letting out an uncomfortable chuckle as she looked to her feet.

"Uh, yeah," she mumbled awkwardly. "Sorry about, uh… everything? I don't feel like I'm gonna make a good case here, really."

Before she could continue, a flash of purple light appeared in front of her, and before she knew it she was enveloped in a hug from Glimmer.

"You might wanna shut up before my mom changes her mind," she teased, giving Catra a pat on the head. "You're not very good at sounding like a hero yet."

Catra grinned in turn as she pushed the princess away with a hand. "Oh, *please* don't tell me you're gonna give me lessons on how to talk like a princess." Both of them, and Adora, giggled.

"No, we're not doing that," Glimmer began as the laughing settled. "But you know what we are going to give you?" Catra looked up at her curiously, as she teleported back away, holding her nose shut with her fingers. "A bath! Cuz you stink!"

Catra gave an offended hiss. "What are you talking about! I smell perfectly normal, right, Adora?" She turned to the other girl in frustration.

Adora laughed. "No, you really do stink."
"Betrayal! By the one person I thought I could trust!"
"Oh, get over yourself," Glimmer teased again, teleporting back in front of her. "It's just a bath."
Catra flashed back a grin of her own. "You'll live to regret underestimating me, Princess."

Chapter 10

It was commonly accepted at that point, the fact that Catra would just roam the castle freely at all hours. She had been given the spare room to stay in as a courtesy, but she usually preferred sleeping at Adora's feet anyway, for the comfort and the company it provided.

It was late afternoon, and the whole castle had an air of calm. It had been long enough that things had finally settled down after the chaotic events that came with Catra's arrival, and now- strange as it was- her presence was growing more and more to become a normal part of life in Brightmoon.

Glimmer was relaxing in her bed, reading through one of the many books her mother had given her, when she noticed Catra come in and silently hop up to her bed and sit in front of her. This, too, was expected. She had never had much of a respect for the privacy of others, and that, it seemed, hadn't changed at all. The entire castle was considered fair play to her, despite the protests of others.

Glimmer reached out a hand to pet the top of her head, an action she never would have thought she'd take a few months ago, much less with such little thought, barely even looking up from her book as she did. "Hey Catra" she casually greeted. In response, Catra let out a soft purr and rubbed her face into Glimmer's hand, surprising her. "What's with you?" she asked with a confused giggle.

"Hey, Sparkles," she asked, still set on purposefully misremembering Glimmer's name. At this point it had become more endearing than it was antagonistic. "I have to ask you something. Something I can't ask Adora. I want an honest answer." Her eyes were scared, yet determined as she looked to Glimmer to convey her understanding. She gave a firm nod, still unsure what this was about, shutting the book and setting it aside.

Catra bit her lower lip as she searched for the words, looking away when she finally spoke, grabbing her arm. "Am I… a good person? Am I really?" Just at that simple question, there were tears in her eyes. Glimmer could tell she'd just been presented with a psychological minefield. A simple "yes" wasn't good enough to satisfy those lingering traumatic doubts.

She ran a hand along Catra's hair again, searching for the right words. "I'll be honest, a while back, I'd have laughed at that question," she joked, hoping to lighten the mood. "I'd say of course not, of course you weren't, because you had a chance to change and you didn't. But I think I've come to realize it wasn't so easy for you, and I think that the fact that you could do it now, well… I think it took a lot of strength and risk, y'know?"

Catra hesitated, her eyes drifting away as she struggled to let the words out. "I only came here because I was afraid of Hordak," she said.

Glimmer shook her head. "Maybe that's what drove it, but if you just wanted to escape, there were other places you could've gone. Places not involved enough in the war for them to find you there. You chose to approach your worst enemies at their home. Because you wanted to make things right."

Catra's ears drooped and she looked at Glimmer again, shame in her expression. "I just wanted to see Adora," she confessed. "I missed her."

Glimmer nodded. "That's okay. She was the one who was hurt the most, it makes sense you wanted to make things right with her."

Catra shook her head. "I hurt you guys, too. I let Shadow Weaver torture you. And I didn't even feel bad about it, not until I came here."

Glimmer paused a bit at the bitter memory, cutting off a "sorry" from Catra as she spoke again. "I don't mind that. You're apologizing now, aren't you? You feel bad now, right?"

There was a pause, before Catra whispered, “I do feel bad. I don’t want her to hurt you, or me, or Adora, or anyone anymore. I want to protect you if I can. I… I care about you, a lot, and I don’t want her to… to hurt you.”

She was shaking, Glimmer could feel that as she ran her hand along her again. “Those aren’t the words of a bad person, Catra.”

Catra’s pleading eyes were on Glimmer now as she spoke, somehow making this once-fearsome rival seem so tender, so vulnerable. “You’re good, I’m sure of that now,” she finished with a smile.

Catra sighed, resting her head against Glimmer’s hand again. “Thanks,” she spoke passively, clearly deep in thought. “That’s good to hear.”

Seeing as how she was distracted, Glimmer let a mischievous grin come onto her face as she planted a kiss on Catra’s head. “You’re a good kitty, don’t worry.”

At that, Catra immediately blushed and looked away, “hey, quit it...!” she shouted. “That’s weird!”

“Aw, what, do you like being called that?” Glimmer teased again. “I’ll be sure to let Adora know too.”

A silent “hmph” came from Catra before she settled down, the air between them now a bit awkward. Finally, Catra began to curl up, laying on Glimmer’s feet and closing her eyes. “Hey, Glimmer…” she began, using the correct name for the first time.

That act had startled Glimmer, who replied with confusion. “Yeah...?”

There was a pause before Catra followed up. “...I love you.”

Glimmer gave a warm smile, leaning back in her bed and petting Catra with her hand. “I love you too, Catra,” she replied, still

shocked she was saying that sentence. “Everything is going to be okay.”

Chapter 11

The castle was quiet, flooded with the darkness of night. Piercing the silence came a scream, waking Adora with a start as she gripped the knife from beneath her pillow, sitting up with a jolting motion and searching the room. It was empty. Catra, who had been laying at her feet, was nowhere to be found.

Nervously, she climbed out of bed, gripping the knife tightly as she explored the room. Still no sign of anyone. Then came another scream, this time she could clearly make it out that it came from down the hall. The spare room.

She rushed out of her bedroom, running down the hall and throwing the large double-doors open. As she expected, that was where she found Catra, cradled in a ball in the corner with a ripped-up sheet from the bed by her feet.

Adora tossed the knife onto the floor just outside the room. It was probably for the best, just to be safe. She approached Catra slowly, walking across the dark room with a caution she had never been able to shake. Shadows made her nervous, even still. Catra's yellow and blue eyes lit up the darkness as she stared with fear at Adora, crawling backwards.

"Adora, I'm crazy!" she hissed. "Stay away from me!" She shook her head, hugging herself in her arms. "I thought I heard her voice but she isn't here! I'm just losing my mind, and it's gonna end up hurting you!"

Adora sighed, a bit relieved, kneeling down and putting a hand gently on Catra's shoulder. "Don't worry about the nightmares. They happen to me too. Even when I'm awake, sometimes I feel it."

She paused, looking down. "It helps to remember that you're safe here. You have support now, and no one is going to be able to hurt you again."

Catra was silent. Adora reached a hand out to touch her arm, still tightly gripping to the other. “Show me your wrists, please. I’m not gonna be mad. I just need to see.”

Another hiss came as Catra grimaced, tightly shutting her eyes. She was resisting, but she loosed her arms enough that Adora could pull one free, revealing a small gash across it. “Catra…”, she whispered sadly.

Catra finally opened her eyes, looking to gauge Adora’s expression. It was sad, that infuriatingly sad look of disappointment. She pulled her arm free. “I’m sorry, okay!? I panicked, I couldn’t… I couldn’t help it. I just panicked.”

Adora shook her head. “I’m not mad. I’m not even upset, really, just… I’m just worried, I don’t want to see you get hurt anymore.”

In an instant, Catra had pulled Adora into a hug, gripping her tightly with the sense of utter terror that she would vanish otherwise. Adora could feel Catra’s claws slightly digging into the skin on her back, but resisted the urge to comment.

“I love you, okay? Please don’t leave me, please don’t give up on me. Please…” Catra whispered, desperately. Adora ran a hand along her back, feeling Catra’s grip loosen and her claws retract.

“Catra, it’s okay, I’m not going to leave you. Not again, not ever.” She pulled away a bit, holding Catra’s hands in her own and helping her to her feet. “Shadow Weaver and Hordak can’t get to you here. You’re safe.”

Adora led her back to the bed, letting her sit. “I’m going to get bandages for those. Wash them off, please.” She turned her back hesitantly and began to leave the room, ensuring she moved slow enough that Catra could stop her if she needed. As she reached the door, she turned back again. “I don’t think you’re crazy, by the way,” she said, a hint of pain in her words. “I’ve been there too.”

It was only a few minutes before Adora returned, the light of the room creating a beacon in the dark castle. Catra was waiting for her as she entered, sitting on the bed.

“H-hey Adora,” she spoke, trying to sound normal but unable to hide the shakiness in her voice. She forced a smile.

“Come on,” Adora said, flashing back a tired smile of her own. “Don’t force it like that, it feels so weird.” She sat on the bed next to her, gripping Catra’s hand in her own, feeling a closeness that had been so unattainable to her for so long.

“I’m here,” Adora said firmly. “And I’m not going to leave again. You’re not going to have to be alone, okay?” Catra gave a weak nod, and offered her arms to Adora again, who got to work on bandaging them.

“Hey Adora?” Catra piped up softly as Adora was finishing up the second bandage. She looked up at her, inviting her to continue. “I want to get better. I really do.”

Adora gave a warm smile as she finished applying the bandage, grabbing Catra afterward and pulling her into a hug. “I know you do,” she spoke through her tears. “I want to help you. We all do.”

Catra returned the hug silently, both of them holding one another in place for awhile, neither wanting to put an end to this bittersweet moment. Finally, Catra spoke again. “I’m going to get better,” she said assuringly, speaking more to herself than to Adora. “I am.”

Adora finally pulled away, smiling wide and giving a nod, tears still dripping down her face. “I’m just so happy, Catra,” she said. “I’m so happy you’re here. I’m so happy you’re safe. I’m happy that you’re going to get better.”

Catra laid her head on Adora’s lap, curling up her body, clearly tired from the chaos the night had brought her. “I’m happy I’m here,” she said. “I like seeing you smile. I missed seeing you smile.”

Adora pet Catra's hair gently, wiping her tears with her free arm. "You're such a dork," she laughed. "I missed that, too."

Before Adora knew it, Catra had fallen back asleep there. Her face was peaceful, calm, hopefully dreaming about something pleasant like chasing a mouse or playing a prank on Kyle.

Before she knew it, Adora was asleep too.

Chapter 12

"Catra, hey, Catra!"

She came awake as Adora shook her, sitting up with a "mrrp" sound, earning her a pet from Glimmer, on her other side. She looked between them sleepily, rubbing her eyes with her hand and letting out a yawn. "What's the deal?" she finally asked.

Glimmer let out a giggle, still moving her hand along Catra. "You'll see in a minute. We have a surprise for you."

After letting out another yawn, Catra gave a groan. "Y'know I'm not keen on surprises from you guys. What, am I going back to jail? I said I was sorry for breaking that vase."

This time Adora was the one giggling, moving to pet Catra herself. "Catra, it's okay, promise. It's nothing bad. You're not in trouble… for once!" She let out another laugh as she finished, resting her head against her to hear the sound of her purring.

"Hey, what gives!?" Catra protested, but notably without going to move Adora. "Well if it isn't bad, what is it?" she asked.

Glimmer gave her a gentle poke to the forehead. "C'mon, use that Force Captain brain of yours. If something isn't BAD, that means it's…?"

"VERY bad," Catra finished. "Oh no, I'm being executed!" Her tone was genuine but her face made it clear she was joking, earning her a kiss from Glimmer.

"You do know good things can happen to you, right?" she asked as she pulled away, her face still close to Catra's.

"I'll believe it when I see it, princess." Catra's tone made it obvious she was joking, but there was a painful truth behind those words nonetheless. It occured to Glimmer at that moment that Catra hadn't exactly had very many good things happen to

her. Probably the best thing would've been that Force Captain promotion, and she had given that up. She planted another kiss on Catra, this time on her cheek.

"Is this all you woke me up for?" Catra teased. "'Cause if so, I'm not *complaining*, but you could've done this whenever."

Adora pulled back at last, tugging on her arm. "No, that's not it. Like we said, we have a surprise for you. A good one."

Catra gave a nervous laugh, hopping from the bed and landing on her feet on the floor, running a hand along her hair to make sure it was in some form of order. Her tail swished about wildly with either curiousity or nervousness as she turned back to look at the other two expectantly.

"Alright then, let's move!" Adora shouted with excitement, hopping up herself and grabbing Catra's hand.

"You *still* haven't explained where we're going," Catra groaned.

"Do you know what a surprise is?" Glimmer teased as she teleported herself in front of them, grabbing Catra's other hand to drag her off with Adora. "Now come on."

They led her together out of the room- Adora's- and down the hall of the castle, up to the large room where meetings of the Princess Alliance were typically held. Catra had been there before, of course, they couldn't stop her, but it was the first time she'd been invited- even encouraged- to go there.

"You ready?" asked Glimmer, looking back at Catra's confused face with a smile as they approached the large doors leading into the room. In response, she gave a nervous, hesitant nod.

As they pushed through the double-doors together, Catra was met with the sight of a large group of people gathered together- the various princesses she recognized from the alliance, members of the rebellion, and Bow providing music with his violin at the front of the room.

Catra looked around, confused. The large table was set up, but there were bowls of snacks on top of it. People were dancing happily, and there was even a banner that said "Happy Birthday Catra!"

Catra squeezed Adora's arm, leaning in toward her and whispering. "Adora, what is this? An ambush?"

Adora laughed, pushing her back lightly. "It's a *party*. We're celebrating you joining the rebellion! It just took a little while to plan."

Catra leaned back in, tapping Adora's shoulder and pointing to a large, winged, four-legged creature in the crowd of partiers. "And what is *that*?"

Adora laughed. "He's a horse. My horse, actually! Or, uh, She-Ra's horse. Although he'd say he's nobody's horse but his own. His name is Swift Wind." Catra looked to Glimmer in the hopes of further clarification, but she just shrugged and laughed.

"Okay so what is a *birthday*?" she asked with confusion as they tugged her off again, into the crowd of the party.

"It's a special day just for you!" Adora explained, looking back with a bright smile. "That means we get to do this every year!"

"That sounds exhausting." Catra replied sarcastically. She paused for a moment, looking around, adding, "...but it could be fun."

As the day went on and the party continued, Catra would find that parties were, in fact, very fun. She was able to dance with Adora and Glimmer, eat snacks, and move about in a room full of people in which- for the first time in recent memory- none of them were mad at her for anything.

As she broke off from one particular dance with Adora, she felt a tap on her shoulder, looking around to see the queen looking at her, gulping nervously and giving a vague, strange, half-hearted bow.

“Catra,” she began, her voice still firm and assertive but noticeably very tired. “I hope you’re enjoying yourself. Everyone was very excited to pitch in. Especially Bow, he went so far as to make the banner and provide music himself.”

“I guess I ought to stop terrorizing him by using his door as a scratching post, huh,” Catra whispered to herself before looking back up nervously.

“In any case,” the queen continued, “I wanted to formally… apologize to you, for any lingering feelings you may have against me. I was doing only what I had to at the time to protect my people.”

“Oh… y-yeah,” Catra mumbled, awkwardly lowering her head and looking at the floor. It was probably the first time she’d been apologized to for somebody with power acting cruel to her.

“In any case,” Angella continued, giving a tired smile and extending her hand. “Welcome to the rebellion.” Catra looked up nervously, with some confusion, her eyes darting between the queen’s face and her outstretched hand. Eventually, she took it, and the two shook hands. The queen gave another tired smile, then turned and walked away.

“Where are you going…?” Catra asked.

“I’ve had fun here,” Angella explained, looking back over her shoulder. “But I have a lot to get done. Please, enjoy yourself.”

With that, Catra watched as she walked out of the room, heading off to plan whatever it was she was always planning. She felt a bit bad for the queen, but there wasn’t time to dwell on it. She turned her attention back to the party.

“Hey!” Glimmer announced with a smile, teleporting in front of Catra, briefly surprising her and making her hair stand on end and her tail grow bushy before settling. “So what did my mom want to talk to you about?”

“Oh, uh, nothing, really…” Catra mumbled, trailing off before looking back up at Glimmer with a grin. “So I guess I’m one of you now, huh, Sparkles? What a pain, from one group of idiots to another.”

“Oh, c’mon,” Glimmer nudged, planting a kiss on Catra’s cheek and standing by her side to take in the view of the whole scene. “You can’t hate it that much. It’s gotta be better than the Horde.”

“Yeah,” admitted Catra casually as she took a step forward, eyes closed as her tail swung behind her. “Mostly ‘cause you guys weren’t there.” When she turned back to Glimmer’s grinning face, she blushed. “Don’t tell Adora I said that.”

“Tell me what?” Adora teased, putting an arm around Catra as she came up behind her. “That you’re a big sap? Oh, I’m already well aware.” Catra gave a brief “hmph” of resistance but accepted her position, blushing wildly. Glimmer, in turn, teleported herself next to Adora, so that Adora could put her free arm around her.

The three laughed, together, surrounded by a group of jovial people, happy to celebrate their once-enemy’s new birthday. For the first time, not only did Catra have Adora, she had others- she had Glimmer, and she had people who cared about her and were happy for her. For once, she felt… safe.

She gave another laugh, her voice cracking, and giving a genuine smile. “Yeah,” she confessed. “Parties are fun.”

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